> and wild narcissus cover the plains. Its spring and autumn are extremely beautiful.

Historian Sunil Sharma has shown that Abu'l Fazl was also able to find a text relating to Kashmir in a more unusual source, the twelfth-century Sanskrit epic *Rajatarangini*, that had been translated to Persian at the Mughal court. In this text, Kashmir is described as the eternal sacred place of Hindus:

> In winter there are hot baths by the river, in the summer the cool river-banks; and the rivers are calm, and not infested with water animals. It is a country where the sun shines mildly being the place created by (the sage) Kashyapa as if for his glory. High school-houses, the saffron iced water, and grapes, which are rare, even in heaven are common here. Kailasa is the best place in the three worlds. Himalaya the best part of Kailasa and Kashmir the best place in the Himalayas.

The best people in Kashmir, according to Abu'l Fazl, despite their lamentable dependence on the 'bonds of tradition', were the Hindus:

> The most respectable class in this country is that of the Brahmans, who notwithstanding their need of freedom from the bonds of tradition and custom, are true worshippers of God. They do not loosen the tongues of calumny against those of their faith, nor beg nor importune. They employ themselves in planting fruit trees, and are generally a source of benefit to the people.

Meanwhile Salim, who 'was ashamed of his former mistake, and was continually showing a desire to obtain this service', was finally able to bring the ladies of the harem to the Mughal camp. Akbar was delighted to be reunited with his family and not long after, 'felt a desire for the coming of Miriam Makani (Hamida Banu)'. He sent envoys to Fatehpur Sikri to escort them to Kashmir with a verse as supplication:

> The pilgrim may go to the K'aaba to perform the haj
> O God! May the K'aaba come towards us!

After several weeks in Kashmir, Akbar reluctantly agreed to leave as the monsoon was about to break. Instead of heading back to Lahore, however, the Padshah decided to go to Kabul, to settle the area. While in Kabul, news